

**HEN HARSH**

PARDESHI received his MBA admission letter from the Auckland University

of Technology, excitement was quickly tempered by uncertainty. “The visa process took longer than expected, and securing accommodation before arrival was a major challenge,” Harsh recalls. Like many Indian students, this year, his journey abroad is no longer a simple leap towards the traditional ‘Big 4’ MBA destinations—the United States, United Kingdom, Canada, and Australia.

Instead, what lies ahead is a more complex, uncertain path shaped by volatile visa regimes, rising education costs, and shifting geopolitical landscapes. The sketch of Indian students pursuing MBAs overseas is being redrawn, demanding sharper strategies, deeper research, and renewed flexibility.

A WIDENING HORIZON

“Mobility is not shrinking but diversifying,” says Saurabh Arora, Founder & CEO of University Living, a global student housing marketplace. “The US remains the largest host with over 1.1 million international students, but recent policy changes, such as the \$100,000 H-1B petition fee, have students thinking carefully about long-term career pathways. Canada, traditionally a strong choice, has seen demand cool after introducing a national study permit cap and stricter post-graduate work permits,” he adds.

Such moves have steered many students towards Europe, where Germany hosts close to 400,000 international students. According to Study in Germany, the nation hosted around 469,485 internation-

al students as of 2023-2024.

France recently crossed 440,000, as per the ICEF monitor, and countries like Ireland and Spain offer streamlined visa processes and attractive post-study work options.

Dubai, with its international branch campuses and long-term visa pathways, is also emerging as a compelling option for MBAs seeking proximity to India and vibrant industry connections. The city now hosts 41 licenced international higher education providers, 37 of which are official international branch campuses approved by the Knowledge and Human Development Authority (KHDA)—Dubai’s education quality regulator.

In the visa calculus, policy clarity and work opportunities weigh as heavily as academic rankings. “Visa policies are now one of the most important factors,” says Arora. In the United States, where a record number of international students are still enrolling, employers now face a one-time \$100,000 fee for new H-1B petitions filed after September 21, 2025.

Coming to the UK, following several years of incremental restrictions, it has now reduced the standard length of its graduate visa for international students from two years to just 18 months. In 2025, Canada imposed a national cap on study permits, limiting approvals to 437,000—a 10% reduction from the previous year’s cap.

Australia has also increased its financial barriers and eligibility standards. Now, international students must now show proof of higher savings (AUD 29,710 for a single applicant), up from AUD 24,505 in 2024.

While these countries still dominate Indian MBA enrolments,